SEBASTIAN FISHER COACHING

CUTTING PHASE

12-WEEK FAT LOSS PROGRAMME

RETAIN MUSCLE · DROP FAT · STAY STRONG

PROGRAMME OVERVIEW

A 12-week training programme designed to preserve muscle mass while dropping body fat. Four sessions per week with strategic cardio. Training volume is maintained where possible — the goal is to keep lifting heavy and let the calorie deficit do the work.

Training split: Upper / Lower / Upper / Lower (4 days/week)
Session length: 50-65 minutes (shorter rest, higher tempo)
Cardio: 2-3 sessions/week (LISS preferred — walking, incline treadmill)
Equipment needed: Barbell, dumbbells, cables, pull-up bar

NUTRITION GUIDELINES

1. Calorie deficit: 300-500kcal below maintenance. Use the calculator at sebastian-fisher.com/calculator.html
2. Protein: minimum 2g per kg bodyweight — non-negotiable during a cut.
3. Fats: minimum 0.8g per kg. Don't go lower — hormones suffer.
4. Carbs: fill the remaining calories. Prioritise around training.
5. Refeed day: every 10-14 days, eat at maintenance with extra carbs. Helps with adherence and leptin.

KEY PRINCIPLES

- Do NOT drop training intensity. Strength is the signal that tells your body to keep muscle.
- Reduce volume before intensity. Fewer sets is fine. Lighter weights is not.
- Rest periods shorter (90sec compounds, 60sec accessories) to keep sessions efficient.
- Cardio is a tool, not a punishment. 20-30min LISS post-training or on rest days.
- If strength drops more than 10%, you're dieting too aggressively. Increase calories slightly.

WEEKS 1-4 — MAINTENANCE VOLUME

DAY 1 — UPPER A

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	RPE	REST
Flat Barbell Bench Press	4	5-8	8	2.5 min
Seated Dumbbell OHP	3	8-10	8	2 min
Cable Fly	3	12-15	9	90 sec
Lateral Raise	3	15-20	9	60 sec
Rope Pushdown	3	12-15	9	60 sec

DAY 2 — LOWER A

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	RPE	REST
Back Squat	4	5-8	8	2.5 min
Romanian Deadlift	3	8-10	8	2 min
Leg Press	3	10-12	9	90 sec
Leg Curl	3	12-15	9	60 sec
Standing Calf Raise	3	12-15	9	60 sec

DAY 3 — UPPER B

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	RPE	REST
Barbell Row	4	6-8	8	2.5 min
Pull-Ups (weighted or bodyweight)	3	6-10	8	2 min
Seated Cable Row	3	10-12	9	90 sec
Face Pull	3	15-20	8	60 sec

EZ Bar Curl	3	10-12	9	60 sec

DAY 4 — LOWER B

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	RPE	REST
Conventional Deadlift	3	4-6	8	3 min
Bulgarian Split Squat	3	8-10/leg	8	2 min
Hip Thrust	3	10-12	9	90 sec
Leg Extension	3	12-15	9	60 sec
Seated Calf Raise	3	15-20	9	60 sec

WEEKS 5-8 — VOLUME REDUCTION

As the deficit accumulates, recovery decreases. Drop 1 set from each accessory exercise. Maintain all compound lifts at full intensity and volume. Increase LISS cardio to 3x/week.

CHANGES FROM WEEKS 1-4:

- Accessories: drop 1 set per exercise (3 sets becomes 2)
- Compounds: maintain all sets and target weights
- LISS cardio: increase to 3x/week, 25-30min
- Refeed every 10 days instead of every 14
- If sleep quality drops, consider a diet break at week 6 (eat at maintenance for 3-5 days)

WEEKS 9-12 — FINISHING PHASE

Final push. Maintain compound intensity at all costs. Accept minor accessory volume drops. Cardio can increase slightly if needed, but food reduction is more effective than extra cardio.

CHANGES FROM WEEKS 5-8:

- Compounds: maintain intensity but allow 1 set reduction if recovery is poor
- Accessories: 2 sets per exercise, higher RPE (push to failure on final sets)
- LISS: 3-4x/week, 20-30min
- Refeed weekly (every 7 days)
- Week 12: reverse diet begins — add 100kcal/week back to maintenance over 4-6 weeks

CARDIO SCHEDULE

PHASE	FREQUENCY	DURATION	TYPE

Weeks 1-4	2x/week	20-25 min	LISS
Weeks 5-8	3x/week	25-30 min	LISS
Weeks 9-12	3-4x/week	20-30 min	LISS

LISS = Low Intensity Steady State. Walking, incline treadmill (10-12% grade, 5-6km/h), or cycling at conversational pace. Done post-training or on rest days. Do not add HIIT during a cut — it competes with recovery.

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